All That Glitters Was Thrown Away

Waste Plastic and Reimagined Preciousness in Contemporary Jewellery



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Image 1: *Brooches* (Siri Hansen 2025)

Abstract

This thesis explores plastic waste as both a material and a concept within a contemporary jewellery context. It is explored through different mediums, such as making, collecting and wearing the pieces. The research examines how discarded plastics can be transformed into jewellery in order to challenge material hierarchies, notions of value and the ethics of production in a time of environmental crisis. The research aims to position the artistic practice within the context of the Anthropocene.

The project introduces the word "*Plasticsmithing"* as a way to describe a jewellery practice that adapts traditional silver- and goldsmithing tools and techniques to work with plastic waste as the material.

The thesis is guided by questions about sustainability, material value and political jewellery. It asks whether jewellery can function as a form of protest. Through experimenting, collecting, melting, cutting and reshaping waste, the work resists the notion of disposability, and instead uses time, care and craftsmanship to give it new value.

Wearability is a central part of the research. By placing waste materials on the body – where precious metals and gemstones are traditionally worn – the jewellery aims to invite the viewer to engage with the jewellery, as well as being an invitation to a conversation about waste and value. Interviews with wearers reveal how meaning can emerge through this interaction. Through this, the wearers become collaborators with the project.

The thesis does not aim to offer solutions, but rather to explore the tension and contradiction between working with sustainability and still producing objects. Ultimately, the research sees waste not as an endpoint, but as a beginning: a starting point for transformation, critique and imagination.

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1. Introduction

1.1 Plastic Dreams

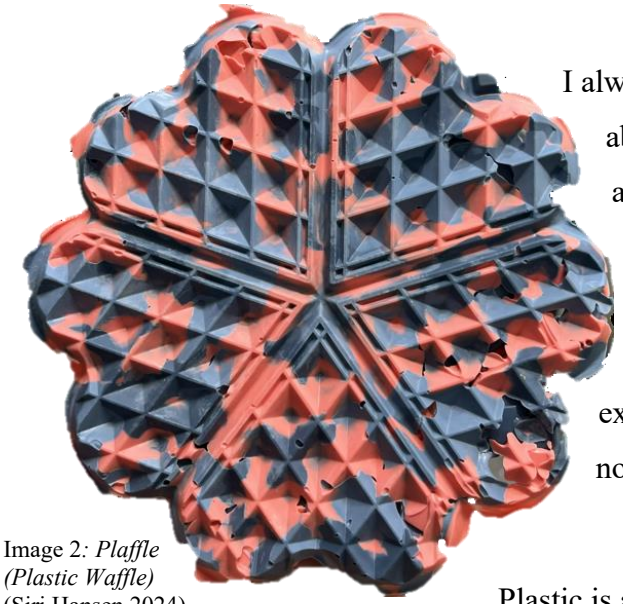


Image 2*: Plaffle (Plastic Waffle)* (Siri Hansen 2024)

I always dream about plastic. I dream about eating it, I eat my plaffles, and put some little microplastics on top, as if it was salt or sugar. I dream about bins filling up with plastic bottles until they explode. I dream about there being nothing other than plastics left.

Plastic is all we have left in my dreams, so we have no choice but to adapt to it; our bodies have to get used to eating it. These dreams are nightmares. I wake up from them all sweaty and scared. Even though they might be exaggerated, they are not too far from the truth. It is horrifying. I continue my day of washing, cutting and melting plastics.

Then I have these dreams again.

1.2 Where it all began for me

With the endless interaction with plastics taking up so much of our everyday lives today, I felt the need to somehow address it in my artistic practice. At the beginning of 2023, I was in my third year out of a four-year Bachelor's Degree at the Glasgow School of Art, specializing in silversmithing and jewellery. This was when I first interacted with plastic not as an object, but as a material. I quickly realised the endless possibilities there were with the material, as well as the endless supply. I had never previously felt so free as I did when working with plastic waste. I made hundreds of samples experimenting with the found materials. I got hooked, and still am.

The term “Plasticsmith” came to me when I was making business cards for myself at the end of my BA. I can identify with the terms “maker” and “artist” as well as “jeweller”, but not so much with terms such as “silversmith” or goldsmith”. I wanted a title that describes what I do, more specific than maker, artist and jeweller do, and that is when I came up with plasticsmith.

1.3 Love and Hate and Material Versatility

I love plastics - their colours, their accessibility, the wide range of shapes and forms and properties they offer. I would argue that there is no material as versatile as plastic. It can be thick or thin, soft or hard, transparent or opaque and smooth or textured. It can masquerade as nearly every other traditional craft material, such as wood, metal, glass, clay and textiles[1], but also materials like feathers, rocks, skin and hair. It is like a chameleon that can take the pattern and look of anything. It's a wonderful material, in many ways.

I also hate plastic. I find it on the ground on my way home, I buy my food wrapped in it, I find it in the ocean where I swim, I cut my food on a plastic cutting board, and I use a plastic spatula to cook it. I jump in the shower and close my acrylic shower curtain and wash myself with soap from a plastic bottle.

Artist Régis Mayot, who makes sculptures out of discarded plastic bottles, said:

> "Plastic is the emblematic material of the end of the 20th century substituting for all the others – wood, metal, glass, fabric... It is the preferred material of industry; saving weight, time, material, energy... and paradoxically, it is the most neglected, the most negatively viewed by the public".[2]

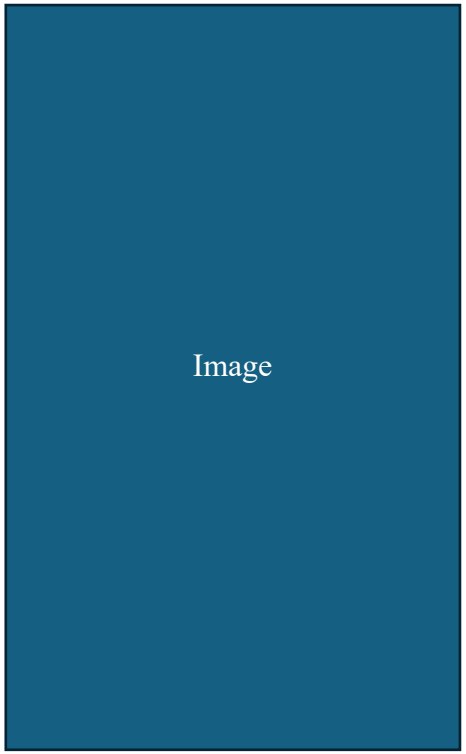


Image 4: *Grand Magasin* (Régis Mayot 2001)

We are surrounded by plastic every day of our lives, yet, we are not caring for the material. When our shampoo bottle is empty, our acrylic jumper gets a permanent stain or our plastic comb breaks, we discard it without thinking twice, and buy a new one.

This is a problem because plastic's versatility and low cost encourage overproduction and disposability, leading to large amounts of waste that the environment cannot absorb. Unlike many traditional

[1] Steven Skov Holt & Mara Holt Skov, *Manufractured: The conspicuous transformation of everyday objects* (Chronicle Books 2008) p.39

[2] Steven Skov Holt & Mara Holt Skov, *Manufractured: The conspicuous transformation of everyday objects* (Chronicle Books 2008) p.53

materials, plastic does not biodegrade, but breaks down into microplastics that pollute soil, water, and even our bodies, harming ecosystems and human health.

1.4 About this paper

In this paper, I will do a deep dive into my own practice. I will write about my process in great depth, as well as the context I am working in, and who else is in this context. I will do interviews with people who have bought my pieces and analyze how the wearers of my pieces can be my collaborators in this project.

Sustainability has always had a central role in my making as well as in my personal life. Living with a lot of climate anxiety, I have always felt the need to do all I can to damage the environment as little as possible. However, how can I be sustainable while still producing objects? Can there ever be environmentally positive aspects of creating objects?

Can jewellery and plasticsmithing act as a form of environmental awareness or protest? How does plastic function as a material symbol of the Anthropocene?

Another important aspect of my practice is to challenge the traditional notions of material value, specifically in a jewellery context where there is a tradition of economically valuable materials. How does working with waste materials challenge traditional ideas of what is valuable or beautiful, specifically in a jewellery context?



Image 3: *Brooches* (Siri Hansen 2024)

2. Process

2.1 Plasticsmithing and the Process

For as long as I have been working with reusing waste plastics, I have never used any specific tools that are designed for this purpose. The word “plasticsmithing” is the best way for me to describe what I do. As I mentioned earlier, I saw a need for a new way of titling myself, and that is when it came to me. Plasticsmithing is a reference to the words gold- and silversmithing, but instead of metal, plastic is my main material. To me, it is an updated version of these words, more relevant for the materials of the era we live in today.

In my early plasticsmithing days, I used an old panini press, which I tried putting all types of plastic in to see what happened. Looking back at it, I should perhaps have been a bit more safety-conscious during my first year of plasticsmithing. When I started out, during my BA at the Glasgow School of Art, I did not have anyone around me working similarly to get technical advice from. When I started off, I really did not think much about the fumes that some types of plastic release. This is something I have since become much more aware of, and my understanding of plastic safety has expanded significantly from doing research online.

After using the panini press, I experimented with using a vulcanizer. A vulcanizer is a machine used for making rubber moulds for wax injection, which is typically used for mass production of jewellery. Switching from the panini press to the vulcanizer gave me much greater - and consistent – pressure on the plastics, which gave me far more control while working. In addition to using these machines, I have made my own moulds in brass and copper. Over the past year, I have experimented with making more complex tools, such as several versions of an extrusion gun in copper. An inspiration for this was British maker James Shaw, who works with plastic waste through a handmade extrusion gun that extrudes the plastics in sausage-like forms, and places them together in different ways.

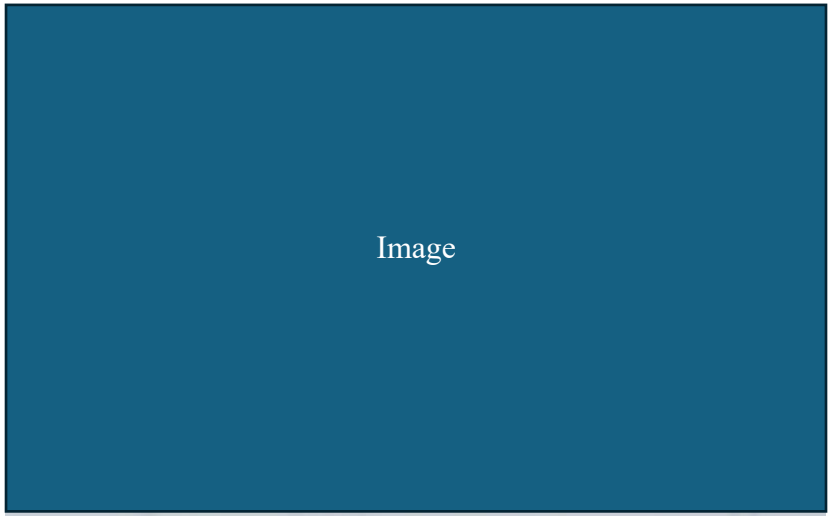


Image 5: *Plastic Extruding Gun (The First) by James Shaw* (Paul Plews & Sasa Stucin. n.d)

Initially, I had ideas to make a similar tool to Shaw's "Plastic Extruding Gun (The First)". I made a lot of sketches and spoke to people with knowledge about building such machines. However, after some sampling and testing, I realised I could make a much simpler tool from copper. To heat the tool, I continue using the vulcanizer, just like before. For pressure, I made a tool that fits perfectly into the copper tube, which I then push by hand.

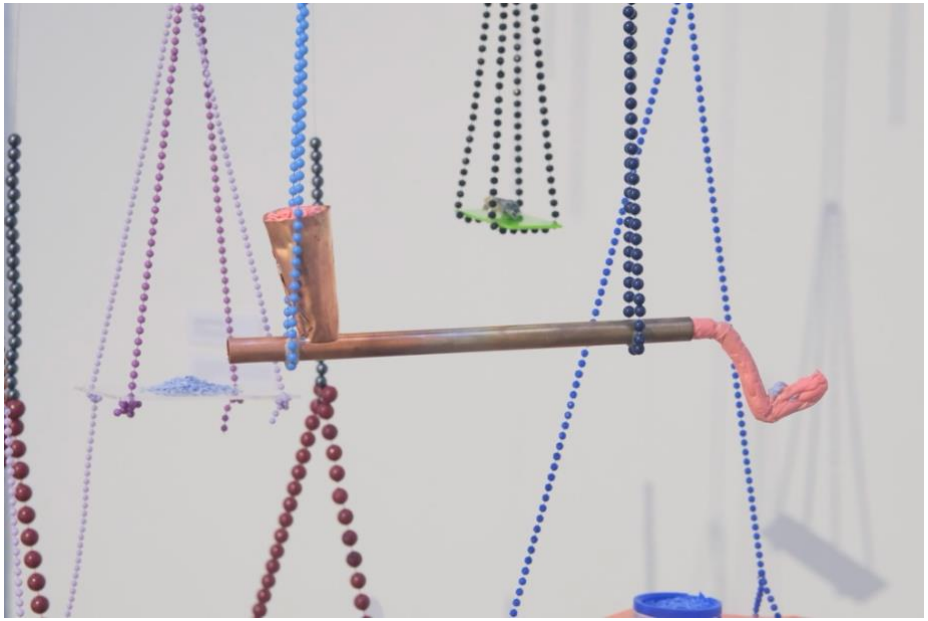


Image 6: *Plastic Extruding Tool* (Siri Hansen 2025)

Being familiar with jewellery and silversmithing tools, it came naturally to me to use these tools when plasticsmithing as well, although often in new, unconventional ways. For example, I use a metal sheet cutter to cut the plastics, I use pliers and a jeweller's saw to adjust and refine, a pendant drill for various things, and a vice and stakes for shaping. I am continually exploring new ways to work with this material.

My making process is highly experimental. On average, I make around 20 samples for each finished piece. I save all of the experiments, and many eventually become something themselves. Since I never had anyone teach me how to work with plastics, all the experiments - past and ongoing ones - are very valuable, and necessary to get to know all the specific properties of the material.



Image 7: *Metal Moulds* (Siri Hansen 2024)

I aim for my approach of working to become a form of critique, just like my finished pieces. My love/hate relationship with the material is always present in the making process. It motivates me and it makes me frustrated at the same time. My process shows that plastic can be understood differently and honoured through the craft that is put into it. My process shows that specialized tools are not always necessary; many tools can, with some creativity, be reimagined and used for more things than their intended purpose. That, too, goes hand in hand with my sustainability perspective on making.

2.2 Gathering and Collecting

Gathering and collecting things is important in my practice. I collect objects and materials that I see potential in. I gather to question the throwaway mindset that has become normalised, living in a capitalistic society. This capitalistic mindset encourages speed, replacement and constant upgrading; objects are only valued for their immediate usefulness. After one use, it is easily discarded. In contrast to this, my practice resists this by holding onto materials, allowing time, imagination and attention to redefine the worth of the object. I need to be surrounded by materials and objects. That is when I feel free. Although I know a lot of people will disagree with me about this, I feel freest when I have all my clutter, found objects and materials around me. I almost do not want to throw out anything, because in the future it could find a purpose. Knowing I can do whatever I want with any of the objects and materials I have collected is what makes me feel at home in my space, and it is what inspires me in my practice. I also get the most motivated to work when I do it in materials that I have gathered myself, because it takes away a lot of the pressure. I am no longer scared of failing, and I can try anything that comes to mind. I'm able to think outside the box and try new things, even when there's no information available—so I never know if something will work until I try it. Most of my pieces have come to life this way.



Image 8: *Plastic Monster* (Siri Hansen 2025)

3. Wearability as a Political Gesture

3.1 I Make Jewellery

I make jewellery. That is what I do. When I started my master's programme, I had some type of goal to try to make sculptural pieces instead. I tried multiple times, but it just was not for me. Making objects instead of wearable jewellery, I felt like I lost important aspects of my practice. I quickly went back to making wearable pieces. The wearability of my pieces is important to me. I want the waste that I make my pieces from to be worn on a body, and to be placed where there might normally be gold, diamonds and other precious materials, like around the neck, wrist, fingers or on the chest. I want the waste to have the same value as the “precious” material. I aim to challenge material value, especially when it comes to plastics. The aim is for the viewer of my pieces to see them as just as valuable as pieces made from precious metals and gemstones. I want the time and craftsmanship to matter to the viewer, much more than the material. In a way, the wearer of my pieces becomes my collaborator. Working with discarded plastics is a deliberate act of protest; the material is loud, loaded and often overlooked. I take something that society has labelled as worthless, and with my care, time and craft skills, I transform it into an object of value. With this, I am trying to say that this material matters. Not because it is rare or expensive, but because it has been rescued and reimagined. By using waste, I want to confront and challenge the overwhelming excess of capitalistic production and consumer culture. This act - of choosing waste - is political.

3.2 Brooches and Pins as a Political Message

Brooches and pins are central to my practice because they operate as quiet but powerful statements. Historically, pins have been used as tools of political expression—from suffrage and civil rights to queer liberation— they are small in scale, but massive in meaning. My work draws on this lineage, but my politics are less explicit. Rather than slogans, meaning emerges through material and engagement.

Plastic itself is a political material: emblematic of mass production, convenience, and environmental neglect. By using discarded plastic in brooches and pins, I turn an overlooked, devalued material into something worn with care. Only through close looking or conversation does the work’s political intent become clear, allowing the jewellery to function as a subtle form of wearable resistance, where the body becomes a site for reflection, responsibility, and dialogue.

3.3 The Wearer's Perspective

As part of my work, I have contacted people who have bought pieces from me, to get their perspective on the pieces. As I see the wearers as being a form of collaborator, I think it is important to get their perspective on it, too. I sent some questions as guidelines, but I encouraged them to speak as freely as they wanted. The questions I sent were:

- Why did you decide to buy the piece?
- How do you feel when you wear it?
- What reactions have you received? And have those reactions changed when/if you mention that the piece is made from waste materials?
- Any other thoughts or comments you'd like to share?

One of the people I contacted, who is the owner of two of my pieces, jeweller and maker Kathie Murphy, told me how she was drawn to the colour and simple shapes, but that she was taken with how they were made. Being a maker herself, she told me the technical achievement was apparent to her. Murphy, similarly to me, makes jewellery out of non-precious materials, mostly resin. She told me:

> "Sadly, I don't think ordinary everyday people appreciate how much work has gone into transforming and manipulating the material."[3]

Murphy's comment highlights a recurring tension many jewellers working with non-precious materials meet. The labour, skill and care put into the piece are often overlooked because, with jewellery, value is often seen to be attached to the material more than anything else.

Another person I contacted was American curator Jane Milosch. She told me that she had bought the piece as a gift, and forwarded the email to the recipient of the gift, but she told me she bought the piece because she loved the concept, colour and that it was lightweight. She liked the simple but jewel-like design.[4]
The recipient of the piece, another American curator, Jo Lauria, told me about a wonderful conversation she had had with a friend, which had started with one of my brooches:

> "In response to your questions for your thesis, I'd like to relate the following as it demonstrates contemporary jewelry's power to initiate conversation:

[3] Kathie Murphy, email correspondence with the author, 10 December 2025

[4] Jane Milosch, email correspondence with the author, 29 November 2025

> When wearing the brooch, a friend inquired what it was made of, and I told her it was fabricated of discarded plastic destined for landfill. This led us onto a discussion of the impact of mining of precious gems and metals (gold, silver, platinum): unsafe working conditions, child labor, environmental destruction all generated for the social-cultural rituals of wearing high value jewelry as signifiers of wealth, status, and "taste." We both agreed that the only ethical way forward in buying jewelry is to choose sustainable, repurposed, and recycled materials (vintage/estate metals and gems that can be redesigned), and to support contemporary jewelry artists who avow to adhere to ethical principles in their sourcing of materials."[5]

Lauria's response reflects on the political aspect of my work. It speaks about how the piece needs to be interacted with for it to announce its origins and story. It is a good example of what I am trying to achieve with my pieces: to spark a conversation. In this way, the wearer becomes an active collaborator who extends the work beyond the object itself into a dialogue. The discarded plastic prompts reflection on responsibility, care and an alternative future for jewellery and other crafts.



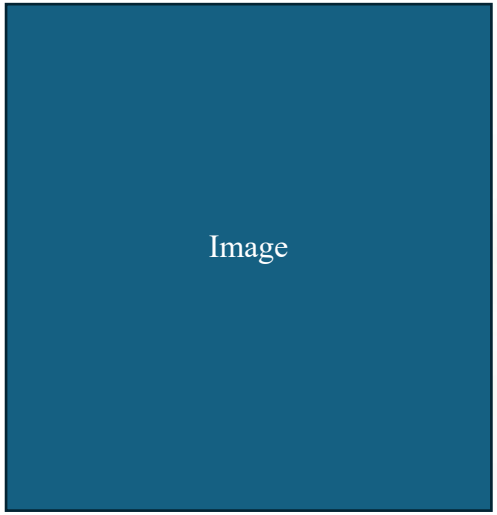
Image 9: *Lauria Wearing the Brooch* (Jo Lauria 2024)

[5] Jo Lauria, email correspondence with the author, 3 December 2025

4. The Anthropocene

4.1 Plastiglomerate

Whenever I go to a beach or walk around a campsite, I try to find something called plastiglomerate. Plastiglomerate is a type of rock, made from plastics mixed with natural sediments, like sand, corals and shells. I have looked on many beaches around Sweden for it, but haven't yet found any here, yet.



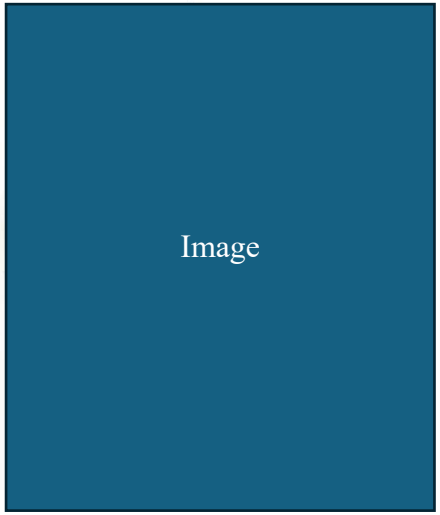


Image 10: *Corals on plastic bottle* (@new___rock 2021)

Image 11: *Plastiglomerate* (@new___rock 2023)

Artist Kelly Jazvac travelled to Kamilo Beach, Hawaii, in 2013, to look for these particular stones now known as plastiglomerate. Before this, these were thought to have formed due to volcanic activity, but because there had been no flowing lava on the beach she visited in the past century, it was realized that these rocks had formed anthropogenically.[6] This means that plastiglomerate is not naturally geologically formed but created through human activity. This could, for example, be through campfires, where plastic had melted and fused together with natural materials. The realization that the stones are anthropogenically made marks a shift in geology: human-made materials are no longer separate from nature but permanently embedded within it.

With plastiglomerate, plastic has become part of the geological record of the Earth. For my practice, these hybrid stones embody the permanence of the materials designed for one-time use, transformed into something that could be eternal. It challenges the idea that waste disappears once discarded, and instead reveals that plastic persists and mutates. It becomes inseparable from nature.

[6] Patricia L. Corcoran, Charles J. Moore, Kelly Jazvac, *An anthropogenic marker horizon in the future rock record* (GSA Today 24, no. 6, 2014)

In February 2025, I went on a field trip to Belgium. Among other things, I visited the coastal town Oostende. I went to the beach and stayed there for hours. It was cold, and every now and then the rain started to spit. The winds felt all the way to my spine. I was determined to find plastiglomerate. I collected all the waste I could find. I threw most of it out, but some of it I took home with me. During this excursion, I did find a couple of interesting objects. I am unsure if any of them would officially qualify as plastiglomerate, but I think some of them could be, as they carry the same hybridity – part organic, part synthetic. Either way, to me, these objects are interesting. One of the pieces I brought back with me was made from seaweed and plastic string intertwined, and some of the pieces seemed to be plastic with some type of natural sediments mixed in with it.



Image 12: *Found objects* (Siri Hansen 2025)

Thinking of, reading about and looking at these plastiglomerate objects made me reflect on how my practice fits within the broader context of the "Anthropocene". Geologists have officially suggested, in August 2016, to rename the current geological epoch the Anthropocene. "Anthropos" meaning human and "cene" meaning new. Although the Anthropocene might not signal the end of the world, it "marks a point of no return".[7] The Anthropocene refers to the mark left by humans, through overconsumption, on species of plants and animals being lost, the population growing, and last, but definitely not least, climate change.[8]

My work engages with this; by working with discarded plastics, I am using the residue of the Anthropocene to sculpt my jewellery. Through collecting and transforming the material, I highlight the human impact on the world, and I try to challenge the possibilities of reimagining value and beauty. I see waste in a new way, not as an endpoint but as a beginning. Plastic takes on an almost gemological role in the Anthropocene — albeit a man-made one. It accumulates in oceans and landscapes, merging with natural elements, and from a jewellery perspective, this hybridity becomes especially interesting.

[7] Eva Horn, *The Anthropocene Sublime: Justin Guariglia's Artwork,* (Art, Theory and practice in the Anthropocene, Vernon Press 2019) p.1

[8] Eva Horn, *The Anthropocene Sublime: Justin Guariglia's Artwork,* (Art, Theory and practice in the Anthropocene, Vernon Press 2019) p.1

With my work, I position my practice as both a response to and a critique of this era. I do not offer a solution to the Anthropocene; I merely aim to participate in the discourse. I seek to navigate an uncomfortable terrain of creating things in a time of overconsumption. My jewellery becomes my way of handling and confronting the reality we live in. Using the Anthropocene's residues to make wearable pieces is my way of engaging with these issues.

Through my craft, I aim to slow down and care for the pieces that have been discarded by others. Through the wearability of my pieces, I aim to bring the waste back into people's lives. By doing this, I hope to make the viewer reconsider how we treat and discard what could be great materials.

4.2 Making in the Anthropocene

I refuse to rely on virgin materials in my practice. There are so many things out there screaming to be reused. I keep doing everything I can to keep my practice sustainable. However, how can I be sustainable while still producing objects? Can there ever be environmentally positive aspects of creating objects? What can my pieces say to the viewer and the wearer of them? These questions are central to my practice, and they inform much of my making process. Living in a world with an extreme amount of over-production happening, creating new objects myself can feel very contradictory to my goal of sustainability. And yet, I do believe there are ways to make objects that challenge rather than contribute to environmental harm.

When making my jewellery out of waste plastics, I am not only reusing materials, but I am also questioning why we discarded them in the first place. This becomes a form of protest, in which I deliberately refuse to participate in the endless demand for new virgin resources. I work with discarded plastics not only to reduce waste but also to generate ideas and possibly new values about the materials of the wearer and the viewer. Transforming waste into art not only saves some material from ending up in landfill but also teaches the viewer to look more carefully at the possibilities of reusing everyday materials. Underappreciated materials, like plastics, can, through being transformed into

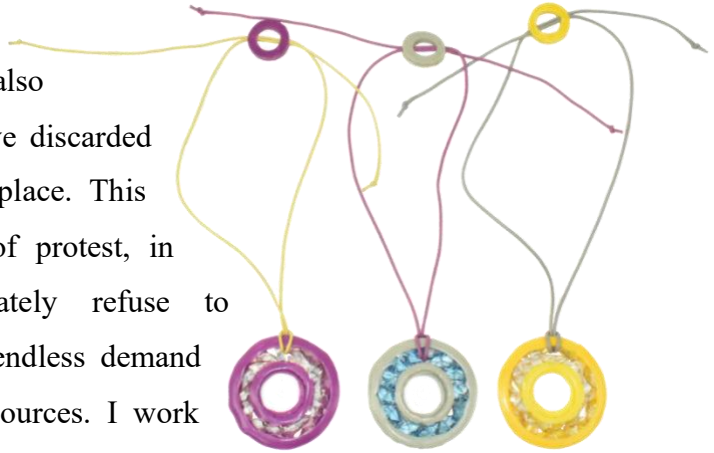


Image 13: *Three Necklaces* (Siri Hansen 2024)

something else, be seen not only for their function, but for their beauty.[9]

Although I do recognize that my practice is not completely without contradiction. Even if all the material is found things that I reuse, I do still consume energy, transport my work, and participate in exhibitions and such, where the main focus is not always sustainability. Despite this, I do not believe that the only ethical choice is to stop making completely. If I continue making with intention, care and transparency, I believe I can still confront overconsumption. I do not claim that my jewellery will save the planet in any way, but I hope it might help in a shift – however small the help might be – in how we think about materials and waste.

4.3 Material Value: What does it mean?

An important part of my practice is to give discarded plastics a new value. I feel an urge to make people understand that we are discarding so much wonderful material, that could be used again and again and for so many things.

I used to think mixing found plastic waste with precious materials was the optimal way to give the waste value, and even though I still like the idea of mixing gold dust and diamonds with plastic dust, I don't think including precious materials is the only way to do this. I think plastic can be seen as precious all by itself. The craft, time and care put into the pieces should be enough for the viewer to understand this. Steven Holt and Mara Holt Skov write about this in their book "Manufractured: The conspicuous transformation of everyday objects:

> "creating something from nothing – that is, from nothing of perceived worth; creativity provides the added value."[10]

Holt and Holt Skov argue that the creativity of the artists, craftspeople and designers can create the value of a piece.

Recently, however, I have worked a lot more with metal together with the plastics, both in the making of my tools as well as in silver to be incorporated into the actual pieces. This gives an interesting contrast to the plastic, both visually as well as contextually. It has also opened a lot of new ways of working, technically. In traditional jewellery

[9] Steven Skov Holt & Mara Holt Skov, *Manufactured: The conspicuous transformation of everyday objects* (Chronicle Books 2008) p.74

[10] Steven Skov Holt & Mara Holt Skov, *Manufractured: The conspicuous transformation of everyday objects* (Chronicle Books 2008) p.36

silver- and goldsmithing, there are a lot of rules and cautions about mixing the metal with anything other than the right alloys for that specific metal. By mixing silver with plastic, I want to disrupt the written and unwritten rules I was previously taught about this.

An important aspect when trying to give value to the discarded is care and time. I care for the plastic just as if it were gold. I collect all the dust and reuse or, if I can't reuse it, recycle it. I spend time sourcing, collecting, cleaning, cutting and shaping the material. Synne Skjulstad, a professor of communication and design at Westerdals, Kristiania University of Applied Sciences, writes in her research paper "Taking care of Plastic: discursive Jewellery and Anthropogenic Debris":

> "In collecting, selecting, washing and embellishing these fragments, the ontology of the chosen pieces is affected and altered. They have become precious. Through this project our own gaze has been interrupted. What we initially perceived as waste is now seen differently."[11]

Skjulstad observes that the destiny of an object previously seen as waste can be fundamentally transformed through acts of attention and care. This resonates well with my own understanding of preciousness: value is not decided by the material itself, but is generated through the labour, intimacy and intention we invest in it. By treating discarded plastic with the same respect traditionally reserved for gold, I am not only elevating the material — I am challenging the hierarchies that define what we consider worthy. In this way, my practice aligns with Skjulstad's insight: when we handle waste with care, we do not only alter the object, we alter our own ways of seeing.

4.4 Bringing waste into a gallery setting

Bringing discarded plastics – or any type of waste really – into a gallery setting can be an effective gesture. It questions what society sees as worthless into something significant. However, turning waste into art, we risk reinforcing the consumerist systems we are trying to critique. Curator and writer Weiyi Chang writes in her essay "After nature and culture: plastiglomerate in the age of capital":

[11] Synne Skjulstad, *Taking Care of Plastic: Discursive Jewellery and Anthropogenic Debris* (Nordic Design Research, No. 8, 2019) p. 10

> "It may be countered that the diversion of plastiglomerate into the gallery context actually intensifies commodification by enhancing the value of what is effectively fossilized garbage through its transformation into an art object."[12]

This paradox is, in a way, central in my own practice. I want to use waste materials to challenge overproduction and perceptions on what is precious and not. Yet I am also aware that by presenting these materials in a jewellery context – where they might be exhibited or sold – I could be contributing to the very culture of consumption that I aim to question. However, by placing waste materials on the body, in locations typically reserved for silver, gold and gemstones, I want to make the viewer rethink what creates value, and that it can come from care, time and transformation, not only from the materiality of it.



Image 14: *Stuff it* (Siri Hansen 2025)

4.5 Challenging Material Hierarchies

With my work, I want to question the traditional hierarchies of materials. Paradoxically, I somehow see this as being both very relevant and completely irrelevant in my practice. In many ways, it is my main topic, and pretty much all I think about. On the other hand, it is what I am trying to erase with my work, and in an ideal world, I would not even have to discuss this topic in my work. I feel like this relationship between hierarchies is very complicated. I want the craft of my pieces to be more important than the material, and I wish more people would be open to the idea of using discarded materials in their craft. I believe we crafters, makers and artists can make a difference. I believe we can also inspire non-crafters/-makers/-artists to rethink their perception of waste, too, as well as of consumption. When plastic becomes the material placed where diamonds and precious metals would often be, like around the neck, fingers or on the chest, I am deliberately disrupting hierarchies of value.

[12] Weiyi Chang, *After Nature and Culture: Plastiglomerate in the Age of Capital,* (Art, Theory and Practice in the Anthropocene, Vernon Press 2019) p. 108

Peter Chang, jeweller and sculptor, worked almost solely in plastics. In the book *Unnatural Selection, Jewellery, objects and sculptures by Peter Chang* by Alyson Pollard, Chang talks about how plastic is considered to have little value.

> "That is true, precious metals and stones, paint and canvas, wood and marble are nothing in themselves until their creative potential is released; plastics are no different."[13]

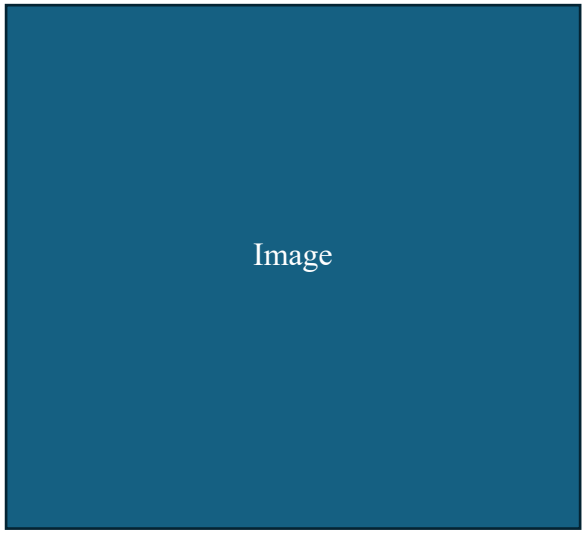


Image 15: *Plastic Bracelet by Peter Chang* (Powerhouse Collection 2004)

In his statement, Chang talks about how, according to him, most material has little value until the craftsmanship comes in. The creative aspect from the craftsperson or artist is, according to Chang, what is most important for a piece to carry value; the material is less important.[14]

Another jeweller working partly in plastics, Benedikt Fischer, said in an interview with writer and jeweller Olivia Shih for Art Jewellery Forum in 2014:

> "Nowadays, the value of a piece should really not be connected to the determined idea of the value of a material. "[15]

I find this mindset very interesting and relevant to my own practice. Interestingly, the materiality often seems to play such a huge role in the context of jewellery, when in most other arts and crafts fields, the material of the pieces plays very little role in what is seen as valuable.

[13] Peter Chang, *Artist's Statement,* (Unnatural Selection, Jewellery, objects and sculpture by Peter Chang, National Museums Liverpool 2007) p. 17

[14] Peter Chang, *Artist's Statement,* (Unnatural Selection, Jewellery, objects and sculpture by Peter Chang, National Museums Liverpool 2007) p. 17

[15] Olivia Shih, *Benedikt Fischer* (Art Jewellery Forum, 2014)

4.6 Reuse Without Endorsement

Another tension I often return to in my practice is the dilemma of working with the waste from different companies – specifically companies that produce and use a lot of plastics in their products – without unintentionally enabling their overproduction. An example of this is the "Snus" companies. Plastic snus containers could easily be reused, I know this for a fact, as it is one of my main materials. The companies making them, however, do not give any thought to what happens with the containers once they are empty. I do not want to solve their problems of creating all this waste for them; this, they will have to do on their own. I do not want to offer them a kind of moral release by giving their waste a new life or "purpose".

I do not aim to sanitize and clean up the consequences of mass production, but rather to expose and question it. By reclaiming materials, I aim to highlight what is being thrown away. It is essential to me that my practice and my work stay critical. My jewellery is a confrontation to the industries, and the materiality is not hidden but emphasised. In this way, I am not fixing their problems but highlighting what they would prefer we do not focus on, which is the waste they are creating.

The research article "Making visible, rendering obscure: reading the plastic crisis through contemporary artistic visual representations" from 2020 discusses the tension of artists working with plastic waste while refusing to offer companies a moral release. The authors discuss how many artists who incorporate discarded plastics, with the aim to highlight the plastic crisis, unintentionally leave out the structural causes behind it in their work. This, together with turning waste into a visually beautiful object, risks an aestheticizing of the problem, according to the article. Without giving a broader understanding of the problem, it can shift into endorsement instead of criticality.[16]

This aligns with my concern that using corporate waste could be misread as a solution for the companies, as I give their waste a new life. My intentions are the opposite, and instead of transforming waste with only a positive narrative



Images 16: *Necklace* (Siri Hansen 2025)

[16] Ekaterina Chertkovskaya, Karl Holmberg, Moa Petersén, Johannes Stripple, Sara Ullström, *Making visible, rendering obscure: reading the plastic crisis through contemporary artistic visual representations* (Global Sustainability 2020)

of renewal, I want to keep the discussion and writing uncomfortable and critical, pointing out overproduction.

5. Contemporary Context

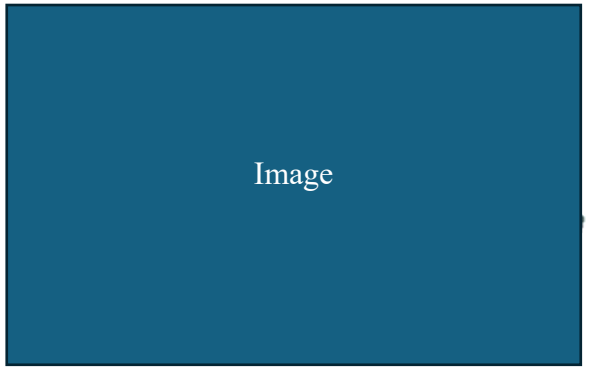
5.1 Contemporary Context: Other Makers Working Similarly

My practice sits within a growing field of contemporary jewellery that engages with waste materials, environmental concerns, and questions of value in the Anthropocene. Some makers working around these themes are Karin Roy-Andersson, Julia Mannheim, and Kristina Kitchener. They all also work with discarded matter, yet each has their own way of doing so. Karin Roy-Andersson often works with non-precious materials that have been thrown away, assembling them into rhythmic, repetitive structures. She mainly uses discarded plastics and reindeer skin in her jewellery. In an interview with Homo Faber, Roy-Andersson says:

> "For me, re-use is not a choice, it is an integral part of how I think and create."[17]

[17] Homo Faber, *Karin Roy-Andersson* (Homo Faber, n.d)

Image 17: *Peacock, brooch, recycled plastics* (Karin Roy-Andersson 2017)



This is something I relate to in my practice and my way of thinking. Her work shows how these discarded materials can gain beauty through repetition, craftsmanship, and abstraction. This focus on structure and transformamtion resonates with my own desire to move the material away from its original context.

Julia Mannheim uses found objects and waste in a way that highlights improvisation, play, and both the old and new identities of the material. Although she allows the past life of the objects to remain visible, what I take from her practice is her openness to material experimentation and her willingness to let unconventional materials carry aesthetic weight.

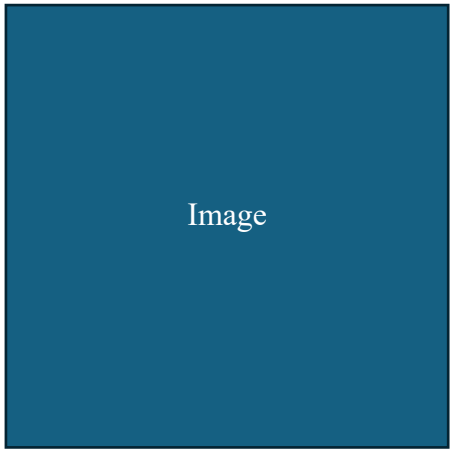


Image 18: *Necklace, treble spiral bangle, pin/brooch and earrings* (Lyon & Turnbull n.d.)

> "By making permanent what is seen to be transient or throwaway, and by making visible what society wants to put out of sight, the value of these 'out of date' objects could be reassessed."[18]

In my practice, unlike Manheim's, I make the waste unreconizable. I aim for the plastic to enter a new identity — shaped, cut, polished, and refined — where value is created through the process.

Another contemporary jewellery artist, Kristina Kitchener, says in her statement on her website:

> "As our attitudes towards plastics and packaging begin to change, the supermarket plastic bag has become the focus in the war on waste. I have been attempting a transformation on these mundane objects using only the most domestic processes in an attempt to generate worth from the worthless, aiming to provoke re-assessment of their value and beauty."[19]

Her pieces draw inspiration from consumer culture. They contribute to the conversation about how we, through jewellery, can mediate environmental issues.[20]

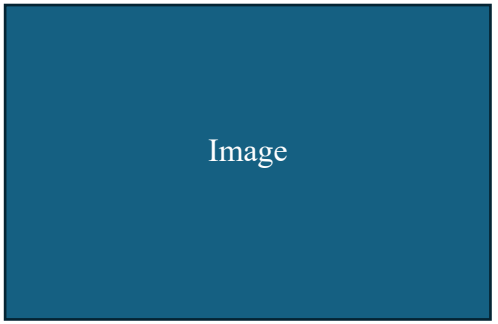


Image 19: *Brooch on Toast, made from bread bags* (Kristina Kitchener n.d.)

The crafts-based transformation is central to my plasticsmithing practice, just like it is important for the practices of the artist mentioned above. The labour of collecting, cleaning, cutting, and reshaping is what gives the material meaning, not its visual legibility as waste.

Placed in relation to these makers, my practice occupies a space between environmental jewellery and material-focused craft. I aim for my work to contribute to a wider dialogue about how jewellery can challenge ideas of preciousness, environmental responsibility, and the aesthetic possibilities of the Anthropocene.

[18] Caroline Broadhead, *Foreword,* (Sustainable Jewellery, Julia Manheim, A & C Black Publisher Limited, London 2009) p. 8
[19] Kristina Kitchener, *Statement,* (KristinaKitchener.com)

[20] Kristina Kitchener, *Mad about jewelry 2014 Kristina Kitchener* (Museum of Arts and Design. MAD About Jewelry, 2014) [accessed 27 Nov 2025]

6. Conclusion

Working with discarded plastics is not a neutral act – it is loaded with political, ecological and material aspects. Throughout this project, I have used plasticsmithing as a way to question how and why certain materials are valued, discarded or overlooked. By transforming waste into jewellery, I am not only engaging in reusing material but actively challenging the perception of value and material hierarchies.

Placing the waste in a spot traditionally reserved for silver, gold and gemstones asks both the wearer and the viewer to reconsider what truly matters when it comes to jewellery: the inherent value of the material, or the time, ethics and craftsmanship put into the pieces?

This thesis has been guided by a set of questions that remain deliberately unsolved. Can jewellery and plasticsmithing function as a form of environmental awareness or protest? Can making objects ever be sustainable in a world already overburdened by production? And how does plastic operate as a material symbol of the Anthropocene? Through my practice, I do not aim to provide definitive answers, but rather to explore these questions through making, researching, conversations and wearing my pieces.

My jewellery works as a quiet form of protest – subtle and wearable – where the political meaning often emerges only through engagement and conversations, as seen in the responses from wearers who become collaborators in the work.

The paradox of creating new objects while trying to be sustainable, in a world overburdened by production, is always present for me while making. I am aware that, even when working with exclusively discarded materials, I still consume energy and other resources. However, I do not believe that the only ethical response to overconsumption is to stop making altogether. Instead, I choose to focus on my making being critical, transparent and intentional. In this way, I think my work can still be meaningful.

Engaging with concepts such as plastiglomerate and the Anthropocene has helped me situate my practice within a broader geological and political context. Plastic is no longer only a material; it has become permanently embedded in nature and even in our bodies. Plastic, in this context, takes on an almost gemological role, not precious because it is rare, but because it is unavoidable and in need of rethinking.

Finally, waste is not an endpoint in my practice, but a beginning. It is a starting point for transformation, imagination and critique. After reusing the waste, I will reuse the waste that comes from working with

the waste. In this way, I redefine preciousness – not as something tied to rarity or monetary value, but as something earned through care, intention and the potential for change.

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9. Appendix

We have now come to the end of the spring exhibition. We have completed an exam exhibition, examinations with external opponents and an audience, and finally, the spring exhibition. We are coming to the end of our time at Konstfack, my project and I, but not to the end of our journey together. For us, things are finally getting started, for real.



Image 20: *All That Glitters Was Thrown Away, Exam Exhibition* (Siri Hansen 2026)

I am going to try to pinpoint a few reflections I have had, what I am happy with, and what I might have changed if I were to do it again. I will also write about some reflections I have received from others about the work. In doing this, I will separate the installation from the individual pieces.

Installation – I think, in some ways, the installation was very successful. I wanted to challenge the norms of traditional jewellery display, and I think I managed to do so. I like that the circles move in different ways, and I think the idea of having to sit down and interact more with the work in this way was successful. I would, however, have really liked to find a way to lift and hold the pieces so you could see their backs, but since there is quite a lot of silver in them, they had to be fastened for safety reasons. I think in the future it could be interesting to think about alternative ways of fastening the work, where they could still be touched, moved and held. Quite a few people were surprised when they were told that the pieces were brooches and not just objects, which I think was both successful and unsuccessful. Successful because then I managed to "get away" from how jewellery is usually shown, unsuccessful since it is quite an important aspect of my work that the pieces can and should be worn. Going forward, this is something I will be much more mindful of when choosing how to display my work.

The pieces – I am very happy with the individual pieces I have made

for my project. I have challenged myself outside my comfort zone and come up with so many new techniques and tools that have made new things technically possible in my work. I actually think that I, two years ago, would have been impressed if she saw my work today, which makes me happy. Going forward, I want to challenge myself by make earrings, necklaces and maybe even rings, but brooches will of course always be my favourite. I will probably come back to mostly making brooches, but I think the technical challenges of making other pieces of jewellery could benefit the work.



Image 21: *All That Glitters Was Thrown Away, Brooches* (Siri Hansen 2026)

I was very pleased to have Sofia Björkman as my main opponent for my examination. I admire Sofia's work, both as a jeweller and as a gallerist, and I think that having someone with so much knowledge about jewellery as an opponent was a real joy. She made some interesting comments related to my work, things I hadn't thought so much about, and I am hoping to stay in contact with her moving forward. For example, she pointed out how a lot of jewellery today is made from cheap materials, but materials that try to imitate precious materials. I think the relation between my work and the cheap "fast-fashion" jewellery could be interesting to look into going forward. I was so nervous before my examination, so even if I think some of my answers could have been better and more on topic, I am mostly proud of just making it through.

Going forward, I am now very excited and scared of what's to come. I have always studied. Right after high school, I started my BA, and right after that, I started my MFA. It feels frightening to get out into the real world and not be able to rely on having CSN (student loan) come in every month, but at the same time, it does feel very exciting. I have one upcoming group exhibition in Helsinki this autumn to work on, and I will be continuously applying for open calls and residencies moving forward. I cannot wait to try my wings and to see my brooches spread theirs out in the real world.

